

THE HOLD-UP

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

You are asked to study the Deal and mentally devise a Plan to make the contract.

HOLD-UP LESSON

The hold-up play is one of the first techniques bridge players learn, right up there with finessing. And the first example they are shown will be something like this one.

You are playing a notrump contract.

Your Left Hand Opponent leads the ♥5 and RHO puts on the ♥Q.

Here is the ♥ suit in dummy's and your hands.

Dummy ♥ 8 4

You ♥ A 10 2

Suppose you take your ♥A at the first (or second) trick. Then, whenever you lose a trick to either opponent they will win some ♥ tricks, four of them if LHO has led a 5-card suit.

But suppose you refuse to win your ♥A until the third round; you hold-up. Then, whenever you lose a trick to your RHO he may be void in ♥s because he started out with just three of them. Since he cannot lead a ♥ back to his partner your contract may be successful.

Of course, even after the hold-up, if you lose a later trick to your LHO he will then cash his ♥ tricks. So hold-up plays aren't always perfect solutions.

The Basic Hold-up:

Look at that ♥ suit in a full example.

The contract is 3NT and West's opening lead is the ♥5. East plays ♥Q.

♠ A 7 3
♥ 8 4
♦ K J 10 9 8
♣ 5 4 2

♠ K 8 2
♥ A 10 2
♦ Q 6 3
♣ A K 10 6

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 2 : Total = 5.

You need 4 more winners, and Dummy's ♦ suit will provide them.

The danger is that West may hold five ♥s, so when you drive out the ♦A, the defense may be able to win 4 ♥ tricks to go along with their 1 ♦.

So you hold-up your ♥A until the third round. Then you play ♦K and continue with the ♦ suit until the defense takes the ♦A. If it is East who wins, and he started with only 3 ♥s, he will have none to return to his partner's hand. And if East does happen to have a fourth ♥ it means the ♥ suit was originally 4-4 and you will only lose 3 tricks in the suit..

Holding Up with a King

The contract is 3NT and West's opening lead is the ♥Q.
East plays the ♥A and returns the ♥9.

♠ A 7 3
♥ 8 4
♦ K J 10 9 8
♣ Q J 2

♠ K 8 2
♥ K 6 2
♦ Q 6 5 3
♣ A K 5

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 3 : Total = 6.

You need 3 more winners, and Dummy's ♦ suit will provide them.
Once East takes the ♥A on the first round the situation becomes identical to the first example.
You hold-up your ♥K until the third round. Then you drive out the ♦A and hope it is East who has it.

Not Holding Up with a King

The contract is 3NT and West's opening lead is the ♥5.
East plays the ♥J.

♠ A 7 3
♥ 8 4
♦ A J 10 9 8
♣ Q J 2

♠ K 8 2
♥ K 6 2
♦ Q 6 5 3
♣ A K 5

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 ? : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 3 : Total = 7.

The opening lead guarantees you a ♥ trick.
And you'd better take it right now or East will return a ♥ and West will take all the ♥ winners he happened to be dealt.

This was not a time to hold up, and after you win the first trick you pin all your hopes on the ♦ finesse. If West holds the ♦K you will make the contract. If East holds the ♦K they are going to bury you with ♥s.

Holding Up with A J x: or not:

When your LHO leads a suit in which you hold A J x and RHO plays a high honor, you have an interesting situation. This holding might be just one stopper, but might be two, depending on which defender will be getting the lead.

The contract is 3NT and West's opening lead is the ♠6.
East plays the ♠Q.

♠ 7 3
 ♥ A 8 4 3
 ♦ Q J 10 9
 ♣ K Q 2



♠ A J 2
 ♥ K 6 2
 ♦ A 6 5 3
 ♣ A 7 5

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ = 1? : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 3 : Total = 7.

Suppose you hold-up your ♠A until the third round.

You need tricks from ♦s and you must finesse through East. If the finesse fails West will take his ♠ winners.

Suppose you take your ♠A at trick one.

You need tricks from ♦s and you must finesse through East. If the finesse fails West will not be able to lead ♠s without setting up your ♠J.

The contract is 3NT and West's opening lead is the ♠6.
East plays the ♠Q.

♠ 7 3
 ♥ A 8 4 3
 ♦ A 6 5 3
 ♣ K Q 2



♠ A J 2
 ♥ K 6 2
 ♦ Q J 10 9
 ♣ A 7 5

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ = 1? : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 3 : Total = 7.

Suppose you take your ♠A at trick one.

You need tricks from ♦s and you must finesse through West. If the finesse fails East will lead a ♠ through your ♠J 2 and West will win a lot of ♠s.

Suppose you hold-up your ♠A until the third round.

You need tricks from ♦s and you must finesse through West. If the finesse fails East will be unable to return a ♠ to his partner (unless they split 4-4).

Holding Up with Two Stoppers:

If you have to establish a suit which is missing two top honors then you may have to hold-up on their suit when you have it double-stopped.

The contract is 3NT and West's opening lead is the ♦J.
East plays the ♦K.

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ A 7 3
♥ A 8 3
♦ 6 5 2
♣ J 10 9 6

♠ = 3 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 0 : Total = 7.

You need to get 2 tricks from ♣s. The danger is that West may have a 5-card ♦ suit that can be established before you can set up any ♠ tricks.

Suppose you take your ♦A at trick one and play on ♣s. If the two high ♣s are split, East will win the first ♣ and play another ♦, allowing West to establish the suit. When you again play ♣s, WEST will take his winner and also take some ♦s.

Suppose you allow East to win the ♦K. He will return the suit and drive out one of your stoppers, but he will use his last remaining ♦ to do so. Now, whenever East takes his ♣ winner he will have no ♦s to help West establish the suit. Since West has only one entry in ♣s he can win it and establish the ♦s, but won't be able to get back in to cash them.

♠ K Q 2
♥ K 6 2
♦ A Q 3
♣ Q 7 5 4

Holding Up at a Suit Contract:

The hold-up is utilized most often when you are playing notrump; the purpose usually being to disrupt communications between the defenders by exhausting one defender of his partner's suit. This use of a hold-up doesn't really apply to suit contracts.

There are other reasons for a hold-up, though, which do apply in suit contracts.

The contract is 4♥ and West's opening lead is the ♠3.
East plays the ♠Q.

Since this is a suit contract count your losers.

♠ 8 7
♥ Q 10 8 3
♦ K 7 5
♣ A J 9 4

♠ = 1 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 1 : Total = 4.

You can't avoid losing 1 ♠, and the ♦A is also a sure loser. If the ♣ finesse works you would be home free, but even if it fails you can guarantee the contract with a hold-up play.

The danger is that if East holds the ♦A, West may obtain the lead and play a ♦ through dummy's ♦K, giving you two ♦ losers. You can prevent that from happening if you can prevent West from getting the lead. Since the only suit West can get the lead with is ♠s, all you have to do is let East win the ♠Q and take your ♠A on the second round.

♠ A 6 2
♥ A K J 6 2
♦ 8 6
♣ Q 10 3

Since East cannot attack ♦s from his side he will have to give you the lead. You pull trumps, then finesse the ♣. Even if the finesse loses East cannot play ♦s without setting up dummy's ♦K, so you will eventually get to discard one of your ♦ losers on dummy's fourth ♣.

15 Practice Deals will be worth more than another 1500 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners

A

Q

9

7

4

Lead: ♥ J

Q

10

5

9

6

2

Q

5

K

J

8

6

A

J

8

Q

8

4

A

7

2

Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 2 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners

7

5

4

2

♣

Lead: ♥ 6

K

J

10

3

Q

7

4

8

5

K

J

6

A

Q

6

5

A

K

5

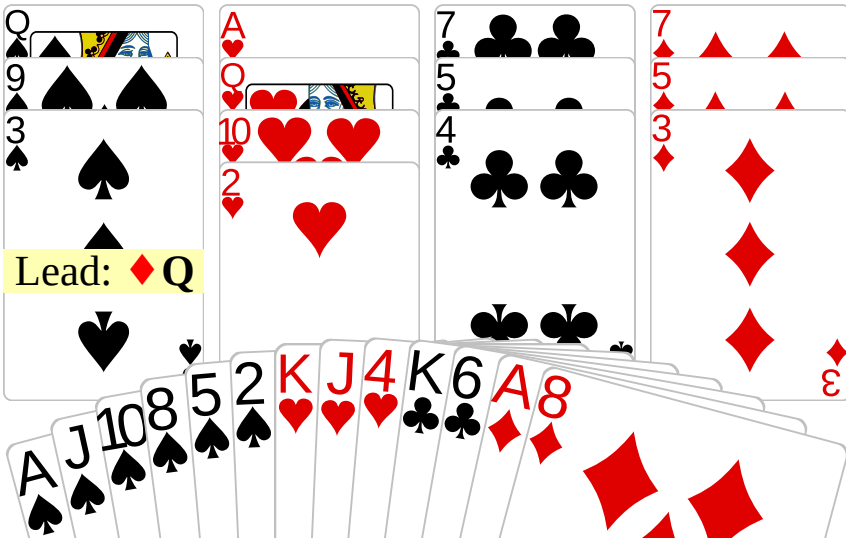
A

7

2

Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 3 Ctr: 4♠ Goal: at most ____ losers



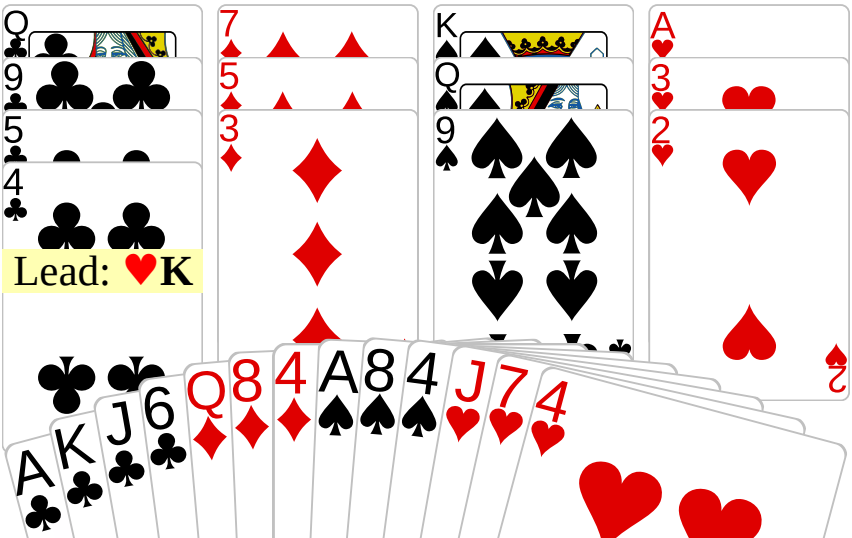
Count Fast and Slow Losers

♠	♥	♦	♣	Total

Decide How to Reduce Losers

Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length

Deal 4 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



Count Sure Winners

♠	♥	♦	♣	Total

Decide How to Develop Winners

Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play

Deal 5 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners

Q

J

10

9

4

Lead: ♠7

K

5

3

A

6

9

6

3

2

K

6

3

A

Q

7

10

9

5

3

A

K

4

Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Board: 1

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: North

Lead: ♥ J

Board: 2

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: East

Lead: ♥ 6

Board: 3

Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4 ♠

Declarer: South

Lead: ♦ Q

Board: 4

Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: West

Lead: ♥ K

Board: 5

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: North

Lead: ♠ 7

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ 10 7 3
♥ K 6 4 3
♦ K 7 3 2
♣ 5 2

♠ Q 8 4

♥ A 7 2

♦ A J 8

♣ K J 8 6

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A K J 5

♥ J 10 9 8

♦ 9 6 4

♣ 10 3

♠ 9 6 2

♥ Q 5

♦ Q 10 5

♣ A Q 9 7 4

West

North

East

South

1NT

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by North

Lead: ♥J

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥J. You try dummy's ♥Q but West plays the ♥K.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=1 ♦=1 ♣=5 Total = 7

Things do not look good. You have only one ♥ stopper, the ♠ suit is wide open, and you have to have the ♦ finesse to get the two extra winners you need.

First problem: Do you hold up the ♥A or not?

No, don't hold up. If you do they might take 4 ♠ tricks immediately, then go back to ♥s. Since your only hope of making this contract is the ♦ finesse you should grab the ♥A, play 5 rounds of ♣s then finesse for the ♦K.

Or not.

Remember: don't hold up when it gives the defenders a good opportunity to switch.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

♠ Q 7 4
♥ 8 5
♦ K J 10 3
♣ 7 5 4 2

♠ J 10 8 2
♥ Q 10 4
♦ 9 7
♣ A 10 8 3

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A K 5
♥ A 7 2
♦ A Q 6 5
♣ K J 6

♠ 9 6 3
♥ K J 9 6 3
♦ 8 4 2
♣ Q 9

West	North	East	South
		2NT	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			
3NT by East			
Lead: ♥6			

East is to play 3NT. South leads the ♥6, dummy plays the ♥5 and North the ♥Q.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=1 ♦=4 ♣=0 Total = 8

Needing only one more winner you decide to hold up on the first ♥ and also the ♥ continuation. You take your ♥A on the third round, South having used the ♥3 to drive out your ♥A.

North returns the ♥10.

South wins with the ♥J and continues with the ♥3; dummy discards a ♣ and North plays the ♥4.

You need one trick from the ♣ suit, so you win 4 ♦ tricks, then the ♠A, ♠Q, putting you in dummy. Next you play a ♣ from dummy, and when North plays low you put on . . . which ♣?

You need one trick from the ♣ suit, so you win 4 ♦ tricks, then the ♠A, ♠Q, putting you in dummy. Next you play a ♣ from dummy, and when North plays low you put on . . . which ♣?

This is not a guess. If South has the ♣A he will get the lead and when he does he will set you with 2 more ♥ tricks. So you assume that North has the ♣A and play your ♣K.

This is a lesson about holding up, and if you had not held up twice in ♥s you would certainly have gone down.

But it's not enough to just be smart enough to hold up, you must also be able to figure out how to make the best plays later as well.

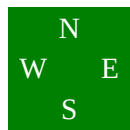
Board 3

South Deals

None Vul

♠ K 6
 ♥ 8 7 3
 ♦ Q J 10 4
 ♣ A 8 3 2

♠ Q 9 3
 ♥ A Q 10 2
 ♦ 7 5 3
 ♣ 7 5 4



♠ 7 4
 ♥ 9 6 5
 ♦ K 9 6 2
 ♣ Q J 10 9

♠ A J 10 8 5 2
 ♥ K J 4
 ♦ A 8
 ♣ K 6

West	North	East	South
			1 ♠
Pass	2 ♠	Pass	4 ♠
All Pass			

4 ♠ by South

Lead: ♦ Q

you a trick. Whatever else he plays you win, pull trumps, and discard a ♣ loser on dummy's fourth ♥.

At notrump you usually hold up to exhaust one player of a suit so he cannot lead that suit back to his partner.

At suit contracts the most common reason for a hold-up is to keep the Danger Hand from getting the lead.

South is to play 4 ♠. West leads the ♦ Q, dummy plays the ♦ 3 and East the ♦ 9.

Losers: ♠=1 ♥=0 ♦=1 ♣=2 Total = 4

On the plus side dummy has an extra ♥ winner on which you could discard a loser from your hand. The danger is that when you take the trump finesse, West might win the ♠ K and put his partner in the lead with the ♦ K for a ♣ play through your ♣ K.

To prevent that from happening all you have to do is hold up on the first ♦. You have to lose one trick in the suit no matter what, so lose it right now to West, the Safe Hand. West continues with another ♦ which you win.

You go over to dummy with a ♥ and play the ♠ Q, letting it ride. West wins with his ♠ K, but cannot play ♣s from his side of the table without handing

Board 4

West Deals

Both Vul

♠ A 8 4
♥ J 7 4
♦ Q 8 4
♣ A K J 6

♠ 7 6 3

♥ K Q 10 8 5

♦ K 10 9

♣ 7 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ K Q 9

♥ A 3 2

♦ 7 5 3

♣ Q 9 5 4

♠ J 10 5 2

♥ 9 6

♦ A J 6 2

♣ 10 8 3

*West**North**East**South*

1NT

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by West

Lead: ♥K

West is to play 3NT. North leads the ♥K, dummy plays the ♥2 and South the ♥6.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=1 ♦=0 ♣=4 Total = 8

Unless there is a miracle in the ♦s, (or a defensive error), you can't get a trick in that suit. But you have a chance for a second ♥ trick.

It's the Bath Coup again, just dressed up a little differently.

Let North hold the first trick, playing the ♥7 from your hand to conceal the ♥4 in the hope that North will continue the suit. If he does you have your ninth trick - if he doesn't, good luck.

Compare this Bath Coup to the one in Deal 10.

Board 5

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ Q 4
 ♥ Q J 9 8
 ♦ J 8 6 2
 ♣ 8 7 2

♠ 10 9 5 3

♥ A K 4

♦ A Q 7

♣ K 6 3



♠ K J 8 7 2

♥ 10 7 5

♦ 10 9 4

♣ A 5

♠ A 6

♥ 6 3 2

♦ K 5 3

♣ Q J 10 9 4

West	North	East	South
	1NT	Pass	3NT

All Pass

3NT by North

Lead: ♠ 7

by leading his small x. If East can get in with the ♣ A he will run the ♠ s.

But what will West do if you play dummy's ♠ A? If he plays his small one the ♠ suit will block. If he unblocks his honor card then your ♠ 10 9 5 3 will provide a second stopper in the suit. So you go up with dummy's ♠ A and guarantee the contract.

A tough finish that needs some real visualization to get right.

Of course from now on you will recognize it.

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♠ 7.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=3 ♣=0 Total = 6

It's pretty clear that your extra tricks are going to have to come from the ♣ suit. The danger here is that East may have a 5-card ♠ suit that he can establish and the ♣ A as an entry. So what is the best approach, hold up or not hold up?

To answer that question you must think about East's lead. Since he did not lead the ♠ K you know he doesn't have a suit headed by K Q J. So you can visualize West sitting there with a doubleton honor in ♠ s. It might be ♠ K x, ♠ Q x or ♠ J x, but it is surely one of those three.

Think what West will do if you duck in dummy. He will play his honor, win the trick, and clear the suit